Disagreement About Nothing: A Pre-Registered Stress Test of a Persona-Ensemble Measure of 10-K Complexity

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Abstract

LLM pipelines that score financial filings make harness decisions that are rarely reported: how much of the filing to read, in what unit, and on which serving backend. We stress-test one such pipeline under a plan registered before any filing was scored. The measure is persona disagreement. One fixed model (`gpt-oss-20b`, a single `bf16` backend) reads every 1,200-word window of a filing's complete MD&A through three analytical lenses, and the embedding distance between their rationales is taken as an index of interpretive complexity. On 59 filings from 30 firms the measure passes the checks such measures usually report: it clears a same-prompt noise floor (1.64×), is stable across three sentence encoders, and is uncorrelated with length, readability and dictionary tone. It fails the check that matters. Replacing real MD&A with content-free safe-harbor boilerplate *raises* disagreement, on two model families; disagreement falls as a window carries more figures; and filing-level split-half reliability is 0.239. The pre-registered size test is null ($p = 0.235$). On the harness side, a 2,000-word budget truncates 99.1% of 785 10-Ks and moves Fog and Loughran–McDonald uncertainty for large firms only. For the LLM measure, reading those 2,000 words as one block yields a significant size effect ($p = 0.029$) that disappears under windowing, weakens to $p = 0.191$ on a second `bf16` backend serving the same weights, and cannot be attributed to coverage. We close with a short reporting checklist for LLM-derived text measures in finance.

Keywords

large language models, financial disclosure, 10-K, evaluation, measurement validity, pre-registration, harness engineering

1 Introduction

A growing body of work asks language models to read corporate disclosure and return a number: a sentiment score, a forecast, a complexity rating [8, 12]. Before any of that happens, someone has to decide how the filing reaches the model. Annual reports run to tens of thousands of words, so the text is cut to a budget, or split into chunks and the chunk scores averaged, and the calls are routed to whatever endpoint serves the model. These choices are usually reported in a sentence. They are also exactly the kind of choice a workshop on harness engineering and evaluation should care about, because they sit between the data and the conclusion and nobody checks them.

We built a measure, wrote down in advance how it would be tested, and then tested it until it broke. The measure asks whether a filing pulls different analytical perspectives apart. Three personas (a value investor, a disclosure-language analyst, a fundamentals analyst) read the same text under one fixed model, and the distance between their written rationales is the score. The hypothesis was the obvious one: smaller, less-followed firms write filings that are harder to interpret, so their filings should split the lenses further.

The paper makes three contributions.

A validity failure that standard checks miss. Persona disagreement clears a noise floor, survives a change of encoder, is uncorrelated with length and tone, and shows no familiarity effect. Each of those is a check papers in this area commonly report. It still does not measure what it was built to measure: content-free boilerplate produces *more* disagreement than real MD&A on two model families, and disagreement is highest where a window offers nothing concrete to agree on. A measure of this kind is responding to the absence of information, not to the difficulty of interpreting it.

Harness choices move the answer, but not the one we expected. A fixed reading budget makes coverage a function of firm size across 785 10-Ks, and it distorts two established textual measures for large firms only. For the LLM measure, though, a careful decomposition shows coverage is not what matters. Reading the first 2,000 words as one block produces a significant, monotone size effect; reading the same filings complete, in windows, does not. Neither coverage nor averaging accounts for the gap, and the single-block result itself weakens sharply when the same weights are served by a different `bf16` provider.

A pre-registered null, reported with the diagnostics that explain it. The confirmatory size test, a pre-registered battery for window-count artifacts, a Holm-corrected secondary family, a pre-specified exclusion, and an exploratory test on continuous public float all fail to find the predicted gradient. Filing-level reliability of 0.239 explains why: most of the variance lives between windows of the same filing. We turn the lessons into a reporting checklist (Section 7).

2 Related Work

Complexity in disclosure. Accounting research has measured the readability and length of annual reports for decades and related them to earnings persistence, information processing and obfuscation [2, 10]. Loughran and McDonald showed that general-purpose word lists and readability formulas misfire on financial text and built finance-specific alternatives [13–15]. Those measures are the natural benchmarks for any new complexity score, and we use them as such.

Disagreement. Divergence of opinion has long been treated as economically meaningful [3, 16]. Our measure is a mechanical cousin: dispersion among prompted lenses applied by one model to one text, rather than dispersion among analysts.

LLMs on financial text. Recent work applies language models to disclosure summarization and return prediction [8, 12], and a parallel strand warns that models may have memorized the firms and periods under study [4]. In the ML literature, disagreement among sampled outputs is used as an uncertainty signal [9, 19]; our placebo result is a caution about reading such disagreement as a property of the input. Long inputs degrade retrieval [11], and nominally deterministic LLM settings still vary across runs [1]; both bear directly on the harness choices we test.

3 Data and Harness

3.1 Sample

30 firms in three size tiers of ten, each contributing its most recent 10-K and 10-Q filed after July 1, 2024, for 59 filings (one firm was acquired and delisted before filing a 10-K and contributes a 10-Q only). The model card for `gpt-oss-20b` states a June 2024 knowledge cutoff [17], so every filing postdates the model's training data. The sample is frozen in a manifest pinned by ticker, form and date, and the whole analysis reproduces offline from cached filings and cached model output. Code, cached model output, the analysis plan and the deviation log are at https://github.com/aryanch09/interpretive-complexity-pilot.

3.2 Complete-section extraction

MD&A and Risk Factors are extracted whole, with no word cap. This turned out to be the hardest engineering in the project, and the failures it uncovered are silent under a cap. One large bank's "MD&A" initially ran to 107,257 words because the span continued into the financial statements. A standard HTML-cleaning step that drops small tables deleted item headings that some filers render as one-cell tables, which removed one large-cap filing's entire Risk Factors section and silently truncated three large-cap MD&As. Both errors ran in the same direction as the confound studied below: they shortened *large-cap* text. After the fixes, MD&A runs from 2,675 to 30,340 words, every filing yields a usable MD&A, and the 10 filings without Risk Factors are 10-Qs that incorporate the 10-K's risk factors by reference, each verified by hand.

3.3 Windows, personas and serving

Each section is split into non-overlapping 1,200-word windows (a remainder under 400 words merges into the previous window). Every window is read by three persona prompts under one model, openai/gpt-oss-20b, at temperature 0.3, with no interaction between calls. Each persona returns a 0–100 score, a confidence, a 3–5 sentence rationale and key factors (Appendix A). This is a prompt ensemble: the model is held fixed and only the analytical lens varies. The run covers 667 windows and 2,001 calls; 363 of the windows are MD&A, and 30 of 30 firms and all 59 filings survive the rule that drops any window in which a persona failed.

All calls go to a single provider at `bf16`, with routing fallbacks disabled. This is a methodological requirement rather than an optimization. The router we used serves this model from many endpoints at fp4, fp8, `bf16` and undeclared precision; default load-balancing would mix them, and some of the measured disagreement would then be a quantization artifact. The pipeline logs which backend served each call and fails the run if more than one did.

3.4 Measures and pre-registration

Window-level disagreement is the mean pairwise cosine distance between the three rationales' sentence embeddings [18], computed with `all-MiniLM-L6-v2` (primary), and the standard deviation of the three scores (secondary). A filing's value is the unweighted mean over its MD&A windows; a firm's is the mean over its filings. The firm is the unit for every confirmatory test.

The analysis plan was committed before any filing was scored (commit `fec1eb2`, amended 2 times before scoring, final `c22f5dd`). It fixed the primary outcome (MD&A only), one confirmatory test (a one-sided Jonckheere–Terpstra trend test [7] on firm means, with a label-permutation check), a battery of window-count tests with pass criteria, a two-sided secondary family under Holm correction [6], and a definition of a null. Every deviation is logged (Appendix B), including one correction made after a number had been computed.

4 What the Harness Does to the Answer

4.1 Coverage is a function of firm size

We measured complete narrative length for 785 10-K filings drawn across public-float deciles, with zero model calls, taking size from `dei:EntityPublicFloat` on each filer's own cover page. Extraction succeeded on 98.1% of 800 attempts, and a seeded random spot check of 20 extractions found 20 that began at a real MD&A heading and ended before the financial statements. Narrative length rises with float (Spearman $\rho = 0.161$, $p < 0.001$), so a fixed budget reads a smaller share of a larger firm's filing. At 2,000 words the median filing in the smallest float decile is read at 13.4% and in the largest at 9.3% (Figure 1).

The gradient is real but modest; the elasticity of length on float is 0.0527. The blunter fact is the level. A 2,000-word budget truncates 99.1% of filings, an 8k-token budget 93.8%, and even 32k tokens cuts 39.7%. In our own stratified sample the retired 2,000-word cap read the median large-cap filing at 12.9% and the median small-cap at 27.5% ($\rho = -0.415$ between size rank and share read, $p = 0.001$).

Established measures inherit the confound. To check that this matters outside our own measure, we computed Fog [5] and Loughran–McDonald category shares [13] on each firm's MD&A twice, complete and truncated at 2,000 words, with identical code. Truncation raised large-cap Fog by +1.86 points [+0.21, +3.79] and large-cap uncertainty share by +0.28 percentage points [+0.02, +0.56], while mid- and small-cap Fog moved by -0.43 and +0.38. That is the coverage mechanism: large-cap filings are the ones a cap cuts hardest. The small-minus-large Fog gradient moves from +0.08 complete to -1.41 truncated. With ten firms per tier most intervals are wide, so we present this as directional evidence that the confound is not specific to language models.

4.2 For the LLM measure, the scoring unit matters, not coverage

The retired version of this pipeline read each filing's first 2,000 words of MD&A as a single unit. Re-scoring exactly that, with the same model, filings and personas, gives a monotone size gradient of 0.0571 ($p = 0.029$), against 0.0150 ($p = 0.235$) for the complete, windowed run; the paired per-firm difference is 0.0356 [0.0172, 0.0540]. An earlier version of this work read that as truncation

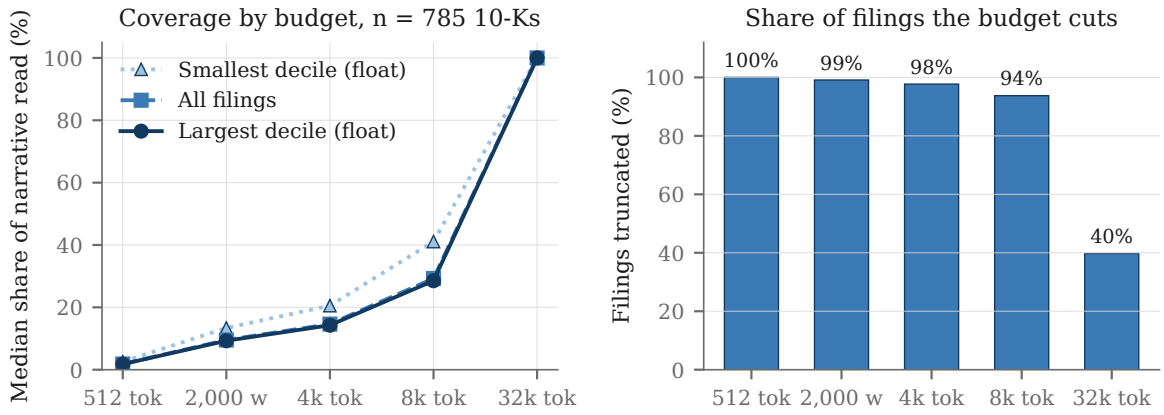


Figure 1: Fixed reading budgets across 785 10-Ks, with firm size taken from each filer's own reported public float. Left: median share of the MD&A plus Risk Factors narrative that fits in the budget, for the smallest and largest float deciles. Right: share of filings the budget truncates. Token budgets converted at 0.75 words per token.

Table 1: The size gradient (small minus large, firm-level means of MD&A persona disagreement) under different harness choices. Backend A is the provider used for the main run; backend B is a second `bf16` provider serving the same weights. p is the one-sided Jonckheere–Terpstra test.

Text read	Unit, backend	Gradient	p
Complete (pre-registered)	windows, A	0.0150	0.235
Complete	1 random window, A	+0.0152	–
First 2,000 w	one read, A	0.0571	0.029
First 2,000 w	one read, B	+0.0295	0.191
Complete	one read, B	+0.0435	0.074
Coverage effect (same unit, same backend)		-0.0139	
paired per-firm: -0.0252, 95% CI [-0.0534, +0.0027]			
Averaging effect (all vs. one window)		+0.0002	
Unit effect (one read vs. windows)†		+0.0285	

†Confounded with backend; indicative only.

Table 2: Validity checks on window-level MD&A persona disagreement. "Pass" means the result is what a valid measure of interpretive complexity would show.

Check	Result	Verdict
Noise floor: 3 lenses vs. 1 lens ×3 ($n = 27$)	ratio 1.64 [1.52, 1.75]	pass
Persona-free baseline (neutral ×3)	+0.1395 [0.104, 0.175]	pass
Encoder swap (2 alternatives), window ρ	0.713, 0.755	pass
Length, Fog, L–M tone, TTR	all $\lvert\rho\rvert \leq 0.212$, n.s.	pass
Anonymization (firm identity removed)	+0.0071 [-0.0153, +0.0297]	pass
Real − sentence-shuffled, gpt-oss	-0.0173 [-0.0470, 0.0142]	**fail**
Real − boilerplate, gpt-oss	-0.0389 [-0.0654, -0.0110]	**fail**
Real − boilerplate, Llama-3.3-70B	-0.0238 [-0.0467, -0.0002]	**fail**
Figures per word vs. disagreement	$\rho = -0.260$	**fail**
Filing split-half (Spearman–Brown)	0.239	**fail**
Same firm, 10-K vs. 10-Q	$r = 0.276$ ($p = 0.147$)	**fail**

manufacturing a false positive. The decomposition in Table 1 does not support that reading.

The two arms differ in three ways at once: how much text is read, whether it is read in one block or in windows, and how many scores are averaged. Averaging can be isolated for free. Taking one random window per filing instead of the mean of all of them leaves the gradient at +0.0152, an averaging effect of +0.0002, as it should be, since averaging changes the variance of a filing mean and not its expectation. Coverage needs one more arm: the complete MD&A scored as a single unit. Scoring both single-unit arms on the same backend, the coverage effect on the gradient is -0.0139, paired -0.0252 [-0.0534, +0.0027]. That is the opposite sign to the claim, and the interval spans zero. What remains is the scoring unit, about +0.0285, and that comparison is confounded with backend.

The backend matters on its own account. The truncated single-read arm was run on both providers, at the same precision and with the same weights and prompts; the gradient is 0.0571 ($p = 0.029$) on one and +0.0295 ($p = 0.191$) on the other. We do not think this means either provider is wrong. It means a cross-sectional result at $n = 30$ can sit within the variation introduced by serving infrastructure [1], which is a reason to pin and report the backend, and to treat any single significant contrast from one serving configuration with suspicion.

Two cautions apply to the decomposition. A single read of a complete MD&A (up to 30,340 words) is the design we originally rejected because long-context degradation is worst for the longest sections [11], which belong to the largest firms, so that arm carries a size-correlated bias of its own; the decomposition bounds the effects rather than identifying them. And because the measure itself turns out to be invalid (Section 5), what the scoring unit is changing is not interpretive complexity. The defensible harness finding is narrow: for this class of LLM measure, how a filing is chunked and on what it is served moved the cross-sectional answer more than how much of it was read.

5 Is Persona Disagreement a Measure?

Table 2 collects the checks. The top block is what such measures are usually validated with, and our measure passes all of it.

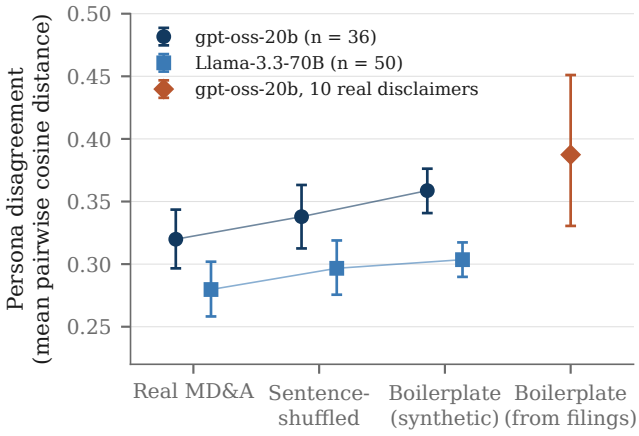


Figure 2: Content placebo. Mean persona disagreement with 95% bootstrap CIs on real MD&A windows, the same windows with sentences shuffled, and forward-looking-statement boilerplate. A valid complexity measure should fall on boilerplate. It rises, on both model families. The rightmost point uses 10 distinct disclaimers taken from the sample's own filings and compares to all 362 real windows.

What it passes. Running one persona three times on the same window gives a noise floor; three different lenses disagree 1.64× as much, and three copies of a neutral analyst prompt sit at the floor, so the lens does work the sampler does not ($n = 27$ windows, 11/8/8 by tier; the planned subset was cut short by rate limiting). Re-encoding the cached rationales with `all-mpnet-base-v2` and `bge-small-en-v1.5` gives window-level rank correlations of 0.755 and 0.713, and all three encoders agree there is no size effect ($p = 0.18$ to 0.38). Filing-level disagreement is uncorrelated with log length ($\rho = -0.148$), Fog (-0.007), and Loughran–McDonald negative (-0.083), uncertainty (-0.032) and litigious (+0.072) shares; the largest correlation, with type-token ratio, is 0.212 ($p = 0.107$). Stripping firm names and tickers changes nothing (+0.0071), and no tier's anonymization delta clears zero, so the shared model's familiarity with large firms is not suppressing their disagreement.

We note that the first two checks are weaker than they look. Prompts that ask for different things will produce text that embeds differently, so beating a noise floor shows the lenses are distinct, not that their distance tracks anything about the filing.

What it fails. The bottom block asks the question that does bear on the construct: does disagreement respond to the content of the filing?

Placebo. On a stratified subset of 36 MD&A windows we compared real text with two degraded versions: sentences shuffled within the window, which destroys the argument and keeps the vocabulary, and roughly 1,200 words of safe-harbor boilerplate, which is real filing language with no firm-specific content. A measure of interpretive complexity should fall on both. Shuffling is undetectable (-0.0173 [-0.0470, 0.0142]). Boilerplate scores *higher*: 0.3587 against 0.3199 for the real text (Figure 2). The ordering real < shuffled < boilerplate replicates on `meta-llama/llama-3.3-70b-instruct` at `bf16`, pinned to a single provider, on 50 windows, with the boilerplate contrast again clearing zero (-0.0238 [-0.0467, -0.0002]). Because a single synthetic passage cannot separate "boilerplate raises disagreement" from "this passage is odd," we also scored 10 distinct disclaimers harvested from the sample's filings. They average 0.3874 [0.3305, 0.4510] against 0.3291 for real MD&A, with wide spread across passages (SD 0.1029, range 0.2522 to 0.6156). Content-free filing prose raises disagreement on average; it does not do so uniformly.

What it responds to instead. Across all scored windows, disagreement falls as the share of numeric tokens rises ($\rho = -0.260$, $p < 0.001$), while word count barely matters ($\rho = +0.071$). It is higher in Risk Factors (0.3510) than MD&A (0.3291), higher at the start of a section, where overview language sits ($\rho = -0.091$ with position), and higher in windows that mention litigation (+0.0161) or guidance (+0.0121) than in windows about accounting (-0.0088). The extreme windows show the mechanism in the text. The lowest-scoring window in the sample (0.1525) is a large technology firm's MD&A opening dense with growth figures, and all three personas cite the same percentages. The highest large-cap window (0.5550, numeric density 0.002) is a bulleted list of generic risk drivers; the value persona sees a durable moat, the language persona sees hedged uncertainty, and the fundamentals persona writes that the excerpt "offers no quantitative evidence." Given nothing concrete, each lens fills the gap with its own prior. The prompts make this likely by design: the language persona is explicitly asked to assess vagueness, so vague text pushes it toward a different topic than the other two.

Reliability. Odd and even windows of the same filing correlate at $r = 0.136$, a Spearman–Brown reliability of 0.239 for the full filing mean; a firm's 10-K and 10-Q correlate at $r = 0.276$ (Figure 3). 78.3% of window-level variance lies within filings, and the firm-level intraclass correlation is 0.077. Reaching a conventional reliability of 0.70 would take about 37 windows, or 44,550 words of MD&A per filing, far more than a typical filing has. More firms would not fix this. The secondary numeric measure is more reliable (Spearman–Brown 0.520), but, as the next section shows, it runs against the hypothesis.

These results reconcile. The lenses do diverge; the divergence is driven by how much concrete material a passage offers, which varies far more between windows of one filing than between firms; so the filing mean is mostly noise, and what signal it has is vagueness rather than difficulty.

6 The Pre-Registered Size Test

As the plan requires, the numeric measure comes first. Its firm-level means are 0.5978 (large), 0.5981 (mid) and 0.5434 (small): small-caps are *lowest*, the gradient is -0.0544, and the two-sided test does not reject ($p = 0.119$, Holm 0.357). The pre-registered rule for retiring it as a length proxy did not trigger ($\rho = 0.046$ with MD&A length, $p = 0.727$).

The primary embedding measure gives 0.3202, 0.3355 and 0.3352: a gradient of 0.0150 in the predicted direction but not monotone. The confirmatory test does not reject ($J = 169.0$, $z = 0.722$, $p = 0.235$; permutation $p = 0.242$). Dropping the one firm with a single filing, a sensitivity specified in the plan, gives $p = 0.179$. Risk Factors, where

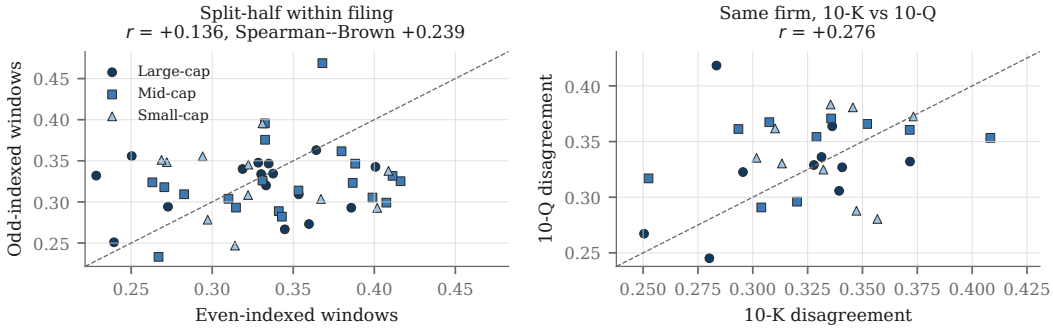


Figure 3: Reliability of the filing-level measure. Left: odd- against even-indexed windows of the same filing (n = 48 filings with at least four windows). Right: a firm's 10-K against its 10-Q (n = 29 firms).

Table 3: Pre-registered and exploratory size tests on firm-level MD&A means (n = 30 unless noted). Gradient is small minus large; the hypothesis predicts a positive gradient and a negative correlation with float.

Measure	Large	Mid	Small	Grad.	p
Secondary family, two-sided, Holm-adjusted p					
Numeric (score SD)	0.5978	0.5981	0.5434	-0.0544	0.357
Risk Factors (n = 28)				-0.0114	1.000
Within-filing SD				-0.0046	1.000
Confirmatory, one-sided					
Embedding (C1)	0.3202	0.3355	0.3352	0.0150	0.235
label permutation					0.242
excl. 1-filing firm (n = 29)				+0.0172	0.179
Exploratory: Spearman ρ with public float					
Embedding	$\rho = -0.295$ [-0.601, +0.109]				0.114

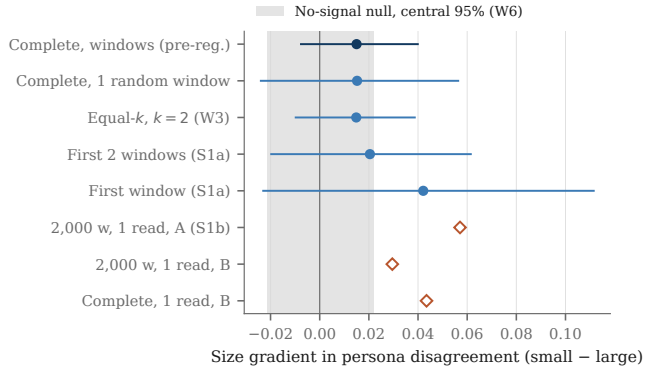


Figure 4: The size gradient under each scoring variant, with 95% intervals where defined (bootstrap, or the 2.5th to 97.5th percentile of resamples). The grey band is the central 95% of gradients produced by the pre-registered estimator when window values are reassigned at random, holding each filing's real window count fixed (W6). Open diamonds are single-read arms from Table 1.

one might expect divergence to live, is flat to negative (-0.0114), as is within-filing dispersion (-0.0046). Under the plan's definition this is a null on all three grounds: the test is not significant, the means are not monotone, and the window-count gate below fails.

Window-count artifacts. Window count rises with tier (ρ = 0.372, p = 0.004): a large-cap MD&A averages more windows. Averaging more windows reduces the variance of a filing mean but not its expected value, so the channels that could bias tier means are composition (a two-window MD&A is half section opening) and window size (tail merges produce windows of 403 to 1,577 words). The pre-registered battery tests both with no new model calls. Subsampling exactly k = 2 windows per filing keeps the gradient's sign in 0.885 of 2,000 draws against a pre-declared threshold of 0.90, so the gate fails. A window-level mixed model with firm random intercepts gives a small-versus-large coefficient of 0.0142 [-0.0126, 0.0411]; the nested firm/filing specification did not converge and is reported as such. A coarsened-exact-matching estimate within window-count bins (+0.0231), position controls (first two windows: +0.0204; dropping each section's opening window: +0.0107) and exact-size windows only (+0.0101) keep the sign, none comes close to significance, and one of the two bins that contain all three tiers reverses it. Reassigning window values at random while holding real window counts fixed produces a null centred on zero with standard deviation 0.0110; the observed gradient sits at its 91.4th percentile (p = 0.086). Window counts, in other words, add noise rather than manufacturing a gradient, and the observed gradient is within the range that noise alone produces (Figure 4).

Is the size variable too coarse? Three tiers discard most of the variation in size, which is the first objection to a null. We retrieved each firm's own reported public float, which spans 27.6 million to 3.6 trillion dollars and orders the tiers almost perfectly (ρ = 0.910). Against continuous float the primary measure runs in the predicted direction, $\rho = -0.295$ [-0.601, +0.109], p = 0.114; the numeric measure runs the other way (ρ = +0.235). The null is not an artifact of binning. A modest negative relation with size cannot be ruled out at n = 30, but given Section 5 it would be a relation between size and vague prose, not between size and interpretive difficulty.

7 Discussion: Lessons for LLM Measurement Harnesses

The measure failed, and we think the way it failed generalizes. Disagreement among prompted views of one text is an attractive quantity because it requires no labels. Our results suggest it has a

default reading that is not the intended one: when a passage gives the model little to anchor on, differently-prompted outputs drift toward their own priors and apart from each other. That is useful to know for anyone using ensemble disagreement as a signal of difficulty, risk or uncertainty in financial text [9]. It is also invisible to the checks people usually run. A noise floor, an encoder swap and a battery of discriminant correlations all came back clean.

On the harness side, three practices would have changed what we believed at several points in this project. Pinning one serving backend at one precision, and logging it per call, made it possible to see that a significant contrast weakened on a second provider. Treating a parse failure as a failure, rather than computing disagreement from the two personas that did respond, removed a bias that was concentrated in large and mid-cap windows (Appendix B). Decomposing a contrast before interpreting it reversed our reading of the paper's original headline.

A reporting checklist. We suggest that papers deriving a firm-level measure from LLM readings of filings report, at minimum: (1) the reading budget and the share of each document it covers, broken out by the variable of interest; (2) the scoring unit and the aggregation rule; (3) the serving backend, precision and routing policy; (4) a content placebo with boilerplate and shuffled text; (5) the reliability of the aggregated measure (split-half and an intraclass correlation) at the unit where the hypothesis lives; and (6) every pre-specified test, including the ones that failed. None of these needs new model calls beyond a small placebo subset.

8 Limitations

Thirty firms is a measure-validation sample, and three tiers stand in for point-in-time size data we did not have; the float test addresses the second point only in part. One model family produced the main results, and the cross-model check covers the placebo only. The noise-floor subset was cut short by rate limiting at 27 windows. The persona prompts are a design choice, and a lens set that did not ask one persona to judge vagueness might behave differently. The decomposition of the truncation contrast relies on a single-read arm with its own size-correlated long-context bias and on a second backend. Public float in the at-scale sample is self-reported XBRL and includes implausible values at the bottom of the range; we use rank statistics for that reason. We report no market outcome. The vagueness reading rests on the placebo, the informativeness correlations and the case studies; we did not collect human judgments, and a blinded comparison of high- and low-disagreement windows, asking raters separately which is harder to interpret and which is less concrete, is the most direct next test.

9 Conclusion

Persona disagreement under a fixed model is real at the level of a single window, stable across encoders, and unrelated to length and tone, and it still does not measure interpretive complexity: it rises on boilerplate, falls with concrete figures, and averages to noise at the filing level. Its pre-registered size test is null. Along the way, the harness choices that are usually left out of methods sections, from the reading budget to the scoring unit to the serving provider, each moved a result that would otherwise have been reported. We would rather the field check these things routinely than learn about them one retraction at a time.

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A Persona Prompts

All three personas receive the same window and the same output schema: `SCORE` (integer 0–100, 50 neutral, with a calibration guide), `CONFIDENCE` (0–1), `REASONING` (3–5 sentences citing the text) and `KEY_FACTORS` (3–5 items). They differ only in framework. The *value* persona weighs intrinsic value, durable advantage, balance-sheet strength and free cash flow. The *sentiment and language* persona assesses how management communicates, including "the specificity or vagueness of strategic language." The *fundamentals* persona weighs revenue and margin trends, execution, and gaps between management claims and reported numbers. Full prompt text is in `agents/prompts.py` at https://github.com/aryanch09/interpretive-complexity-pilot.

B Deviations from the Plan

(1) **Backend switched, then switched back** (before scoring, and before any statistic was computed). The pinned provider was rate-limiting too heavily to finish; the run moved to the only other `bf16` provider, which then degraded (slow responses and empty completions). The 14 firms scored there were discarded, not merged, and all 30 firms were re-scored on the original provider.

(2) **Parse failures now count as failures** (mid-run, before any statistic). The code had treated a persona that returned unparseable text as a success, keeping the window with a two-score standard deviation and, where no rationale could be extracted, a stand-in string for the embedding. That is imputation, which the plan forbids. Twenty-five of the first 331 windows were affected, split 14 large / 11 mid / 0 small.

(3) **Interpretation of the truncation contrast corrected** (after the number was computed). The contrast was originally reported as truncation manufacturing a false positive; the same-backend decomposition (Section 4) shows it cannot be attributed to coverage. The original figures are retained in Table 1.

Not deviations: the extraction fix, persistence of per-window rationales, and a score parser correction were all declared in the plan before scoring.